

The No Trump Play Plan

Your winners are rarely enough: the plan tells you how many tricks are missing, where to find them and how to cash them.

1 Four questions after the opening lead

- 1 How many sure tricks do I have?
- 2 How many more does the contract need?
- 3 Which suits can provide them?
- 4 How do I get them?

2 Entries and communication

Entry: the card that wins the trick in the right hand at the right time.

Link: the card that, thanks to the entry, carries the lead from one hand to the other.

NORTH ♠ 872 ♥ A7 ♦ J10952 ♣ J32
SOUTH ♠ AK3 ♥ K85 ♦ KQ3 ♣ A854
3NT · West leads the 2♥

Winners: 2 spades, 2 hearts, 1 club. Diamonds give 4 more after losing to the ace.

1. Win with the **king of hearts**: the ace stays with the diamonds.
2. Lead **South's diamond honors** first, from the short side.

Protect the entries next to the long suit you want to establish.

3 Count the opponents' tricks too

NORTH ♠ 653 ♥ 32 ♦ AQJ109 ♣ 764
SOUTH ♠ AKQ ♥ A4 ♦ 872 ♣ KQJ105
3NT · West leads the K♥

5 winners, 4 more needed. Clubs would provide them, but only **by losing to the ace**: after the lead the defenders have at least 4 hearts to cash, and with the A♣ that makes 5. Take the **diamond finesse** instead: it doesn't give up the lead.

4 Win in the right hand

NORTH ♠ 763 ♥ 864 ♦ A653 ♣ QJ3
SOUTH ♠ AKQ ♥ A32 ♦ K8 ♣ A10985
3NT · West leads the 2♦

Before winning the lead, decide your next move. Clubs must be led **from North toward South**, to catch the king with East: so win with **dummy's ace of diamonds** and lead the queen of clubs.

5 The duck

N ♣ A72
S ♣ K8653

South has few entries. If declarer plays A, K and another club, the two good clubs have no entry. Better to **duck at once**: the 2 to the 3. Then the A, a club to the K and all the rest.

Give up early a trick you'd lose anyway, to keep communication in the suit.

6 Blocked suits

N ♠ KQ72
S ♠ AJ83
flows

N ♠ QJ109
S ♠ AK
blocked

N ♥ KQ2
S ♥ AJ43
K, Q, then
2 to the A

N ♦ K2
S ♦ AQJ43
K, then
a low card

To avoid blocking: honors from the short side first.

7 Unblocking a suit

NORTH ♠ 6542 ♥ 103 ♦ KQJ102 ♣ 54
SOUTH ♠ A73 ♥ AKQJ2 ♦ A ♣ AK32
West leads the K♠

13 winners, but the singleton ace blocks the diamonds. There is an entry: dummy's **10 of hearts**. South cashes the A♦, plays the 2♥ to the 10♥ and runs the K Q J 10 of diamonds.

Blocked suit? Use the other suits to get around the block.